

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

In DGT, take a look at some of the gadgets we've been tinkering with and the stuff we've been reading and watching. In Feature, we check out the underrated TV show *Psych*. Then head on over to Geek-Key to read about some Ancient Runes



2020 Drone Awards

Check out this gallery of stunning drone shots taken over the course of the year. Shown here is the winner of the Urban category, which is an image of the Petronas towers in Malaysia captured by Tomasz Kowalski. <http://dgit.in/drnwrds>

WHAT'S NEW

How Van Halen hacked his guitar

In this republished article from 2013 in *Popular Mechanics*, the late guitarist Eddie Van Halen describes in his own words the steps he took to hack his guitar, and come up with his patented inventions for the instrument. The changes Van Halen made to his guitar were born out of necessity, to squeeze out the necessary sounds without the required equipment, such as a distortion pedal or a router. This process of modification started with sandpapering the neck of the guitar to make it as flat as possible, so that the fingers could bend the strings to the maximum extent. Another modification was to work around the lacquered wood used in the Fenders, which did not behave well when



the fingers got sweaty. Van Halen fixed this problem by using a natural wood neck, which absorbed the sweat as it was played. Another

problem that Van Halen tackled was getting the distortion out of a Marshall amp, at lower volumes. Unless the volume was turned to 11, the amp would not provide the necessary distortion, but that was too loud for his home. So Van Halen rigged an industrial grade light dimmer to control the voltage supplied to the amp.

<http://dgit.in/vanhalen>

Do we live in a simulation?

In 2003, Nick Bostrom wrote an influential paper on the simulation argument, that explored the possibility of all of us living in a simulated universe, created by beings with computational resources vast enough to create such a simulation. The theoretical or philosophical question is age old. The Chinese philosopher Zhuangzi woke up from a dream of spending a day as a butterfly, and wondered if he



was a butterfly dreaming of being a man. Plato described a group of men chained to a cave, looking at shadows cast by a fire on the wall and giving it names. Everything we perceive, Plato argued, could be

just the shadows on the wall. A new paper using Bayesian reasoning to attack the problem, indicates that the chances of all of us living in a simulation is about 50-50. There are two types of possible realities, parous realities where simulations are possible, and nulliparous realities where such realities are not possible. The paper shows that the vast majority of possible realities are nulliparous. <http://dgit.in/thematrix>



The secret of Nüshu

A secret women's only script in China, that was passed on from mother to daughter may be as old as 3,000 years old. The language was on the verge of dying out but is now making a resurgence thanks to dedicated efforts towards studying and preserving the language. <http://dgit.in/nushu>



100,000 stars

This interactive Chrome experiment lets you explore the night sky in a totally unique way, by looking at the stars in the Milky Way galaxy in three dimensions. You can rotate and zoom your way through the galaxy, and select stars to have specific information on them displayed. <http://dgit.in/3dmw>



That is not bread

An Irish court has ruled that the bread used by Subway has too much sugar in it to be called a bread, and that it should be called a confectionary. Subway has filed an appeal, and the fight for tax reasons because true bread is considered a staple food and exempted from VAT. <http://dgit.in/notbread>